AI ADAPTATION: THE PEOPLE SIDE OF SCALE



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MAICON FORWARD

#MAICON26

Adoption is access.
Adaptation is change.

AI ADOPTION

Introducing and using tools

AI ADAPTATION

Changing how people think, work, lead, collaborate, and create value

FIVE BUILDING BLOCKS

What must exist for adaptation to happen?

01
Skills
Human capabilities that persist

02
Guardrails
Permission and clarity to act safely

03
Workflows
Repeatable ways to change the work

04
Measurement
Evidence that the work improved

05
Culture
Conditions that make learning safe

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Skills

Prompting is a basic skill.
Human capability drives adaptation.

Tool proficiency is table stakes

True adaptation depends on the human skills AI cannot supply for you.

Problem framing
What are we really trying to do?

Critical evaluation
Is this accurate, useful, and complete?

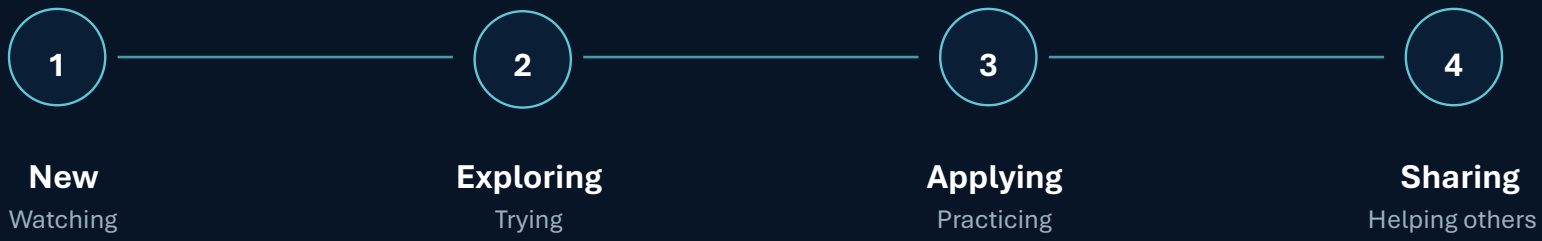
Curiosity
What else could we try?

Context-building
What does AI need to know?

Judgment + taste
Does this meet the standard?

Accountability
Would I stand behind this work?

Capability builds through repeated practice



Training sessions create awareness.
Practice and sharing builds adaptation.

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Guardrails

Governance is table stakes.
Permission and clarity are the differentiator.

Good guardrails create permission and clarity

An AI policy tells people what not to do.
Guardrails tell them how to move responsibly.

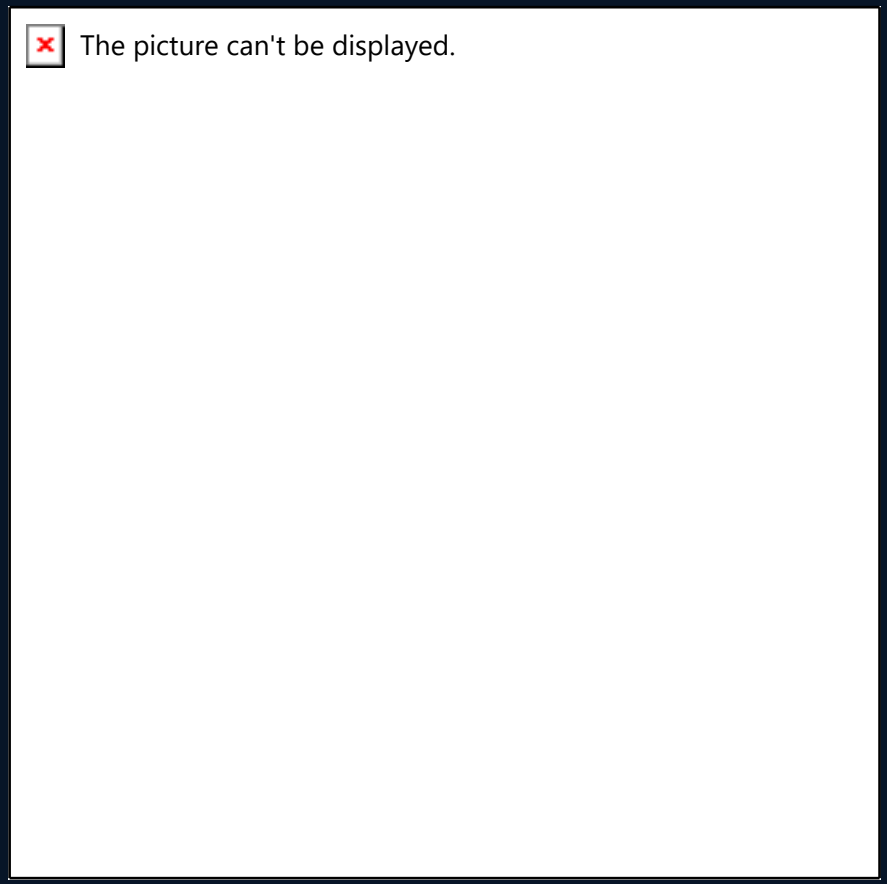
- Which tools can I use?
- What data is safe?
- What needs human review?
- What quality bar applies?
- When do I escalate?
- Who owns the finished work?

People move faster when they know the boundaries.

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Workflows

One good prompt helps a person.
A repeatable workflow changes a team.


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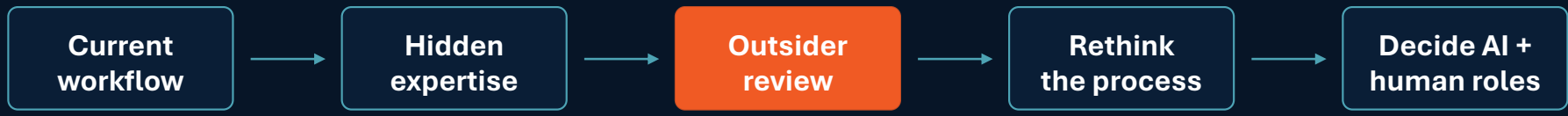
“Operationalizing someone’s brain”

Workflow adaptation is not task automation.
It’s making the invisible parts of expertise visible.

- What is the why behind the work?
- What cases require judgment calls?
- Where does the context live?
- What patterns are there?
- When do we make exceptions?
- What are the signals to slow down or escalate?

Remember: Expertise doesn’t always sit at the top of the org chart.

Redesign before you automate



The real question to ask:
Now that AI exists, should this process work this way at all?

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Measurement

The metrics that matter most are harder to capture.

Don’t just measure AI use. Measure what *changed*.

Easy to count

- Licenses activated
- Weekly active users
- Training hours completion
- Prompts generated

Closer to value

- Cycle time reduced
- Quality + consistency improved
- Rework and handoff friction reduced
- Pipeline and revenue impact
- Real behavior change

Did we save time, or did we move work downstream to someone else?

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Culture

The hardest building block is the one that determines whether the others stick.

“Culture Eats Strategy for Breakfast”

People experience AI through the culture they're in

COMPANY A:
Supportive adaptation

- CMO experiments visibly herself
- Shares what works and what doesn't
- Invests in enablement + tech
- Mantra: "meet people where they are"
- Definition of success: team feels more creative and likes their jobs more

COMPANY B:
Fear-shaped adoption

- PE-backed environment
- Annual layoffs in the background
- Top-down mandated off-the-shelf Claude Skills
- Prescribed use cases, "figure it out" attitude
- Message lands as: "do more with fewer people"

The same AI initiative can land very differently depending on the environment.

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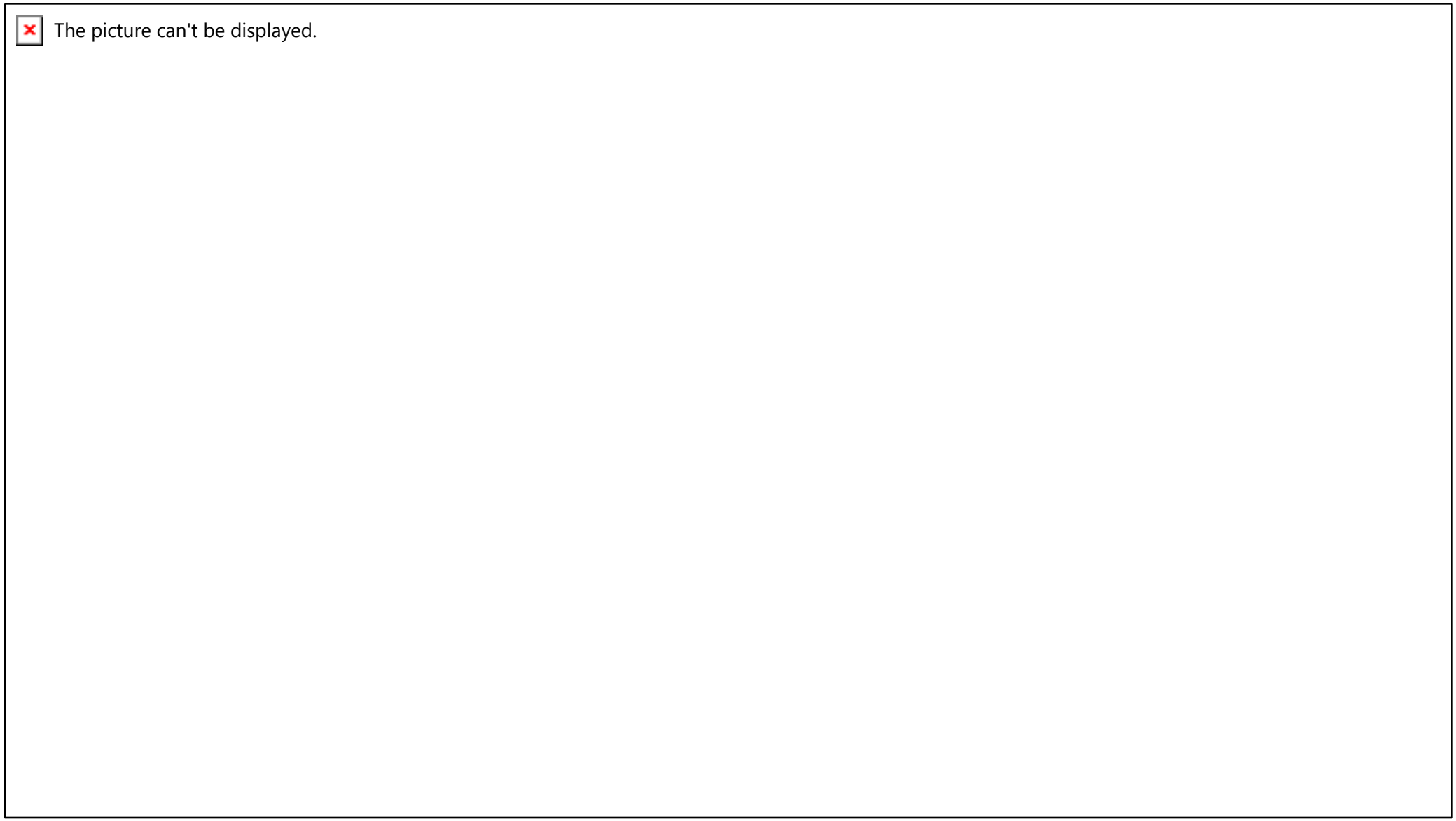
Culture is built by what the leaders model

- Show vulnerability
- Learn in public
- Encourage experimentation
- Reward judgment
- Create peer learning opportunities
- Make it safe to say “I’m stuck”

Leaders must model adaptation, not perform certainty.

The five building blocks of AI adaptation

SKILLS	Build human capabilities that survive the next tool or model.
GUARDRAILS	Give people permission and clarity.
MEASUREMENT	Measure whether the work got better.
WORKFLOWS	Rethink how the work gets done.
CULTURE	Create the conditions for people to keep adapting.


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